coursera | MoMA

Seeing Through Photographs ✕

Today's goal • 3/3 items

Module 1
Introduction to Seeing Through Photographs

Module 2
One Subject, Many Perspectives

Part I: Introduction
- ✓ Introduction to Module 1
  Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Artistic Equivalents
  Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Vik Muniz on Photographing the Familiar
  Video • 3 min

Part II: Telescopes and Cameras
- ✓ Introduction to Part II: Surface, Scale, and Technology
  Video • 2 min
- ✓ Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- ✓ Moons and Surfaces
  Reading • 5 min
- ✓ Hear More: Sarah Meister on Eugène Atget. Pendant l'éclipse. 1912
  Video • 3 min
- ✓ Hear More: Liz Deschenes on Tilt/Swing (360° field of vision, version 1), 2009
  Video • 1 min
- ✓ Surface, Scale, Technology
  Dialogue • 15 min

Part III: Seeing the Unseen
- ✓ Introduction to Part III: Man on the Moon
  Video • 2 min
- ✓ Photographs by NASA
  Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Hear More: Sarah Meister on U.S.G.S. and NASA, Surveyor III. Surface of the Moon, Day 319, W-F. 1967
  Video • 1 min
- ✓ Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- ✓ Who Does the Moon Belong To?
  Reading • 4 min

Part IV: It's Only a Paper Moon
- ✓ Introduction to Part IV: Vernacular and Fine Art Photographs of the Moon
  Video • 3 min
- ✓ Moon Phases
  Reading • 6 min
- ✓ Hear More: Sarah Meister on Ansel Adams. Moonrise, Hernandez, New Mexico. 1941
  Video • 3 min
- ✓ Man on the Moon and Paper Moons
  Dialogue • 15 min

Part V: Review and Respond
- ✓ Optional Readings and Resources
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Practice Memory Check
  Practice Assignment • Grade: 100%
- ✓ Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges
  Reading • 10 min

Module 3
Documents and the Documentary

Part I: Introduction
- ✓ Introduction to Module 3
  Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Sarah Meister on Documents and the Documentary
  Video • 3 min

Part II: Framing Reality
- ✓ Facts and Fictions
  Reading • 6 min
- ✓ Fictions and Facts
  Reading • 6 min
- ✓ Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- ✓ Hear More: Mike Mandel on Evidence, 1977
  Video • 4 min
- ✓ Hear More: Thomas Demand on Room (Zimmer), 1996
  Video • 1 min

Part III: Words and Pictures
- ○ **Artist Spotlight: Dorothea Lange**
  Reading • 4 min
- ○ Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- ○ Hear More: Sarah Meister on Dorothea Lange. Migrant Mother. 1936
  Video • 2 min
- ○ Hear More: Sarah Meister on Dorothea Lange. On the Road to Los Angeles, California. March 1937
  Video • 1 min
- ○ Artist Spotlight: Gordon Parks
  Reading • 4 min

Part IV: Focus on New Documents, 1967
- ○ Introduction to Part IV: Sarah Meister on New Documents
  Video • 3 min
- ○ New Documents: Arbus, Friedlander, and Winogrand
  Reading • 4 min

Part V: Review and Respond
- ○ Practice Memory Check
  Practice Assignment • 20 min
- ○ Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ Optional Readings and Resources
  Reading • 10 min

Module 4
One and Another

Module 5
Constructing Narratives, Challenging Histories

Module 6
Pictures of People

Module 7
Ocean of Images

Artist Spotlight: Dorothea Lange

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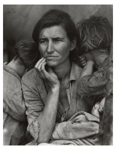
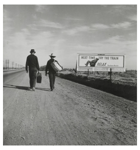


Dorothea Lange. *Migrant Mother, Nipomo, California*. 1936. Gelatin silver print, 12 13/16 × 10 1/8" (32.6 × 25.8 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Purchase

As curator Sarah Meister says in the introductory video to this module, Dorothea Lange is perhaps the "perfect" person to help us think through the matter of documentary photography.

Lange took this photograph in 1936, while employed by the U.S. government's Resettlement Administration (later, the Farm Security Administration), formed during the Great Depression to raise awareness of and provide aid to impoverished farmers. In Nipomo, California, Lange came across Florence Owens Thompson and her children in a camp filled with field workers whose livelihoods were devastated by the failure of the pea crops. Recalling her encounter with Thompson years later, she said, "I saw and approached the hungry and desperate mother, as if drawn by a magnet. I do not remember how I explained my presence or my camera to her, but I do remember she asked me no questions. I made five exposures, working closer and closer from the same direction." One photograph from that shoot, now known as *Migrant Mother* and several variants, were widely circulated to magazines and newspapers and became a symbol of the plight of migrant farm workers during the Great Depression.

Lange described Thompson's situation, stating, "She and her children had been living on frozen vegetables from the field and wild birds the children caught. The pea crop had frozen; there was no work. Yet they could not move on, for she had just sold the tires from the car to buy food." However, Thompson later contested Lange's account. When a reporter interviewed her in the 1970s, she insisted that she and Lange did not speak to each other, nor did she sell the tires of her car. Thompson said that Lange had either confused her for another farmer or embellished what she had understood of her situation in order to make a better story. Nevertheless, Lange's keen sense of composition, and her attentiveness to the power of historical images like that of the Madonna and Child has helped this photograph transcend its original documentary function to become an unforgettable work of art.



Dorothea Lange. *On the Road to Los Angeles, California*. March 1937. Gelatin silver print, 8 1/16 × 7 3/4" (20.4 × 19.7 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of the Farm Security Administration

This photograph depicts two men walking down an unpaved road en route to Los Angeles. As they advance, they get closer to a billboard advertising the Southern Pacific Railroad, which states: "Next Time Try the Train. Relax." The billboard features an illustration of a man reclining in a seat, an image that starkly contrasts with the two men walking on foot. Through this pairing, Lange critiques the luxury and idealism of the billboard while highlighting the difficult reality experienced by the majority of Americans during the Great Depression.

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